Dei Filius

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THE VATICAN COUNCIL'

SESSION III

April 24, 1870

DOGMATIC CONSTITUTION ON THE CATHOLIC FAITH

PIUS, BISHOP,

SERVANT OF THE SERVANTS or GOD, WITH

THE APPROVAL OF THE SACRED

COUNCIL, FOR PERPETUAL

REMEMBRANCE

Our Lord Jesus Christ, the son of God, and Redeemer of mankind, before returning to His Heavenly Father, promised that He would be with the Church Militant on earth all days, even to the consummation of the world. Therefore he has never ceased to be present with His beloved Spouse, to assist her when teaching, to bless her when at work, and

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to aid her when in danger. And this His salu tary providence, which has been constantly dis played by other innumerable benefits, has been most manifestly proved by the abundant good results which Christendom has derived from oecumenical councils, and particularly from that of Trent, although it was held in evil times. For, as a consequence, the sacred doc trines of the Faith have been defined more closely and set forth more fully; errors have been condemned and restrained; ecclesiastical discipline has been restored and more firmly secured ; the love of learning and of piety has been promoted among the clergy ; colleges have been established to educate youth for the sa cred warfare ; and the morals of the Christian world have been renewed by the more accurate training of the faithful and by the more fre quent use of the sacraments. Moreover, there has resulted a closer communion of the mem bers with the visible head and an increase of vigour in the whole mystical body of Christ; the multiplication of religious congregations and of other institutions of Christian piety; and such ardour in extending the kingdom of

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Christ throughout the world, as constantly en dures, even to the sacrifice of life itself.

But while we recall with due thankfulness these and other signal benefits which the di vine mercy has bestowed on the church, espe cially by the last oecumenical council, we can not restrain our bitter sorrow for the grave evils which are due principally to the fact that the authority of that sacred synod has been contemned, or its wise decrees neglected, by many.

No one is ignorant that the heresies pro scribed by the Fathers of Trent, by which the divine teaching (magisterium) of the Church was rejected, and all matters regarding re ligion were surrendered to the judgment of each individual, gradually became dissolved into many sects, which disagreed and con tended with one another, until at length not a few lost all faith in Christ. Even the Holy Scriptures, which had previously been de clared the sole source and judge of Christian doctrine, began to be held no longer as divine, but to be ranked among the fictions of myth ology.

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Then there arose, and too widely overspread the world, that doctrine of rationalism, or nat uralism, which opposes itself in every way to the Christian religion as a supernatural insti tution, and works with the utmost zeal in order that, after Christ, our sole Lord and Saviour, has been excluded from the minds of men, and from the life and moral acts of nations, the reign of what they call pure reason or nature may be established. And after forsaking and rejecting the Christian religion, and denying the true God arid His Christ, the minds of many have sunk into the abyss of Pantheism, Materialism and Atheism, until, denying ra tional nature itself, and every sound rule of right, they labour to destroy the deepest foun dations of human society.

Unhappily, it has yet further come to pass that, while this impiety prevailed on every side, many, even of the children of the Catholic Church, have strayed from the path of true piety; and by the gradual diminution of the truths they held, the Catholic sense has be come weakened in them. For led away by various and strange doctrines, wrongly confu-

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sing nature and grace, human science and di vine faith, they are found to deprave the true sense of the doctrines which our holy Mother Church holds and teaches, and to endanger the integrity arid the soundness of the Faith.

Considering these things, how can the Church fail to be deeply stirred? For, even as God wills all men to be saved, and to arrive at the knowledge of the truth; even as Christ came to save what had perished and to gather together the children of God who had been dis persed, so the Church, constituted by God the mother and teacher of all nations, knows its own office as debtor to all, and is ever ready and watchful to raise the fallen, to support those who are falling, to embrace those who return, to confirm the good and to carry them on to better things. Hence it can never for bear from

witnessing to and proclaiming the truth of God, which heals all things, knowing the words addressed to it: "My Spirit that is in thee, and my words that I have put in thy mouth, shall not depart out of thy mouth, from henceforth and forever."1

Ms. lix. 21.

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We, therefore, following the footsteps of our predecessors, have never ceased, as becomes our supreme apostolic office, from teaching and de fending Catholic truth, and condemning doc trines of error. And now, with the bishops of the whole world assembled round us and judg ing with us, congregated by our authority and in the Holy Spirit in this oecumenical council, We, supported by the Word of God written and handed down, as We have received it from the Catholic Church, preserved with sacredness and set forth according to truth, have deter mined to profess and declare the salutary teaching of Christ from this Chair of Peter, and in sight of all, proscribing and condemn ing, by the power given to Us by God, all er rors contrary thereto.

CHAPTER I Of God the Creator of All Things

The Holy Catholic, Apostolic, Roman Church believes and confesses that there is one true and living God, Creator and Lord of

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heaven and earth, almighty, eternal, immense, incomprehensible, infinite in intelligence, in will and in all perfection, who, as be ing one, sole, absolutely simple and immu table spiritual substance, is to be declared as really and essentially distinct from the world, of supreme beatitude in and from Himself, and ineffably exalted above all things beside Him self which exist or are conceivable (can. i-iv). This one, only, true God, of His own good ness and almighty power, not for the increase of His own happiness, nor to acquire but to manifest His perfection by the blessings which He bestows on creatures, with absolute free dom of counsel, created out of nothing, from the beginning of time, both the spiritual and corporeal creature, to wit, the angelic and the mundane ; and afterwards the human creature, as partaking, in a sense, of both, consisting of spirit and of body.2 God protects and governs by His providence all things which He hath made, reaching from end to end mightily, and ordering all things sweetly.3 For all things

2 Fourth Lateran Council, cap. 1. de Fide Calholica. •Wis. viii. 1.

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are naked and open to His eyes,4 even those which are yet to be by the free action of crea tures.

CHAPTER II Of Revelation

The same holy Mother Church holds and teaches that God, the beginning and end of all things, may be certainly known by the natural light of human reason by means of created things — for the invisible things of Him from the creation of the world are clearly seen, be ing understood by the things that are made;5 but that it pleased His wisdom and bounty to reveal Himself, and the eternal decrees of His will to mankind by another and supernatural way, as the Apostle says : God, having spoken on divers occasions and in many ways in times past to the fathers by the prophets, last of all, in these days, hath spoken to us by His Son6 (can. i).

It is to be ascribed to this divine revelation that such truths among things divine as of

* Heb. iv. 13. 6 Romans i. 20. • Heb. i. 1 f .

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themselves are not beyond human reason can, even in the present condition of mankind, be known by every one with facility, with firm assurance, and with no admixture of error.7 This, however, is not the reason why revelation is to be called absolutely necessary; but be cause God of His infinite goodness, has or dained man to a supernatural end, viz., to be a sharer of divine blessings which utterly ex ceed the intelligence of the human mind; for eye hath not seen, nor ear heard, neither hath it entered into the heart of man, what things God hath prepared for them that love Him.8 (Can. ii and iii.)

Further, this supernatural revelation, ac cording to the universal belief of the Church, declared by the sacred Synod of Trent, is con tained in the written books and unwritten tra ditions which, received by the Apostles from the mouth of Christ Himself, or from the Apostles themselves, by the dictation of the Holy Spirit, transmitted, as it were, from hand to hand, have come down even to us.9 And

TSumma Theol. 2 a 2ae, ii. 4.

81 Cor. ii. 9.

8 Council of Trent. Sess. IV, de Can. Script.

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these books of the Old and New Testaments are to be received as sacred and canonical in their integrity, with all their parts, as they are enumerated in the decree of the said council, and are contained in the ancient Latin edition of the Vulgate. These the Church holds to be sacred and canonical; not because, having been carefully composed by mere human industry, they were afterward approved by her author ity; not because they contain revelation, with no admixture of error; but because, having been written by the inspiration of the Holy Ghost, they have God for their author, and have been delivered as such to the Church itself '(can. iv).

And as the things which, in order to curb rebellious spirits, the holy Synod of Trent decreed for the good of

souls concerning the interpretation of Divine Scripture have been wrongly explained by some, We, renewing the said decree, declare this to be its meaning: that, in matters of faith and morals, apper taining to the building up of Christian doc trine, that is to be held as the true sense of Holy Scripture which our holy Mother

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Church hath held and holds, to whom it be longs to judge of the true sense and interpre tation of the Holy Scriptures ; and, therefore, that it is permitted to no one to interpret the Sacred Scripture contrary to this sense or likewise contrary to the unanimous consent of the Fathers.

CHAPTER III Of Faith

Man being wholly dependent upon God, as upon his Creator and Lord, and created rea son being absolutely subject to uncreated truth, we are bound to yield to God, by faith in His revelation, the full obedience of our intelli gence and will. And the Catholic Church teaches that this faith, which is the beginning of man's salvation, is a supernatural virtue, whereby, inspired and assisted by the grace of God, we believe that the things which He has revealed are true; not because the intrinsic truth of the things is plainly perceived by the natural light of reason, but because of the au thority of God Himself, Who reveals them,

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and Who can neither be deceived nor deceive (can. ii). For faith, as the Apostle testifies, is the substance of things hoped for, the evi dence of things that appear not.10

Nevertheless, in order that the obedience of our faith might be in harmony with reason,11 God willed that to the interior help of the Holy Spirit there should be joined exterior proofs of His revelation, to wit, divine facts, and especially miracles and prophecies, which, as they manifestly display the omnipotence and infinite knowledge of God, are most certain proofs of His divine revelation adapted to the intelligence of all men (can. iii and iv). Wherefore, both Moses and the Prophets, and most especially Christ our Lord Himself, showed forth many and most evident miracles and prophecies, and of the Apostles we read: "But they, going forth, preached everywhere, the Lord working withal, and confirming the word with signs that followed."12 And again it is written: "We have the more firm prophetical word, whereunto you do well to attend, as to a light that shineth in a dark place.

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10Heb. xi. 1. "Mark xvi. 20.

11 cf. Rom. xii. 1. "II Pet. i. 19.

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But though the assent of faith is by no means a blind action of the mind, still no man can assent to the Gospel teaching, as is necessary to obtain salvation, without the illumination and inspiration of the Holy Spirit, Who gives to all men sweetness in assenting to and believ ing in the truth.14 Wherefore faith itself, even when it does not work by charity,15 is in itself a gift of God, and the act of faith is a work appertaining to salvation, by which man yields voluntary obedience to God Himself, by as senting to and cooperating with His grace, which he is able to resist (can. v). Further, all those things are to be believed with divine and Catholic faith which are contained in the Word of God, written or handed down, and which the Church, either by a solemn judgment or by her ordinary and universal teaching (magisterium) , proposes for belief as having been divinely revealed.

And since without faith it is impossible to please God,16 and to attain to the fellowship

14 Second Council of Orange, confirmed by Pope Boniface II A.D. 529, against the Semipelagians, can. vii.

15 cf. Gal. v. 6. "Heb. xi. 6.

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of His children, therefore without faith no one has ever attained justification; nor will anyone obtain eternal life, unless he shall have perse vered in faith unto the end.17 And that we may be able to satisfy the obligation of embracing the true faith and of constantly persevering in it, God has instituted the Church through his only-begotten Son, and has bestowed on it manifest marks of that institution, that it may be recog nized by all men as the guardian and teacher of the revealed Word; for to the Catholic Church alone belong all those many and ad mirable tokens which have been divinely es tablished for the evident credibility of the Christian Faith. Nay, more, the Church itself, by reason of its marvellous extension, its emi nent holiness and its inexhaustible fruitfulness in every good thing, its Catholic unity arid its invincible stability, is a great and perpetual motive of credibility, and an irrefutable wit ness of its own divine mission.

And thus, like a standard set up unto the nations,18 it both invites to itself those who do

"Matt. x. 22; xxiv. 13. "Is. xi. 12.

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not yet believe, and assures its children that the faith which they profess rests on the most firm foundation. And its testimony is efficaciously supported by a power from on high. For our most merciful Lord gives His grace to stir up and to aid those who are astray, that they may come to a knowledge of the truth;19 and to those whom He has brought out of darkness into His own admirable light, He gives His grace to strengthen them to persevere in that light, deserting none who desert not Him. Therefore there is no parity between the con dition of those who have adhered to the Catho lic truth by the heavenly gift of faith, and of those who, led by human opinions, follow a false religion; for those who have received the faith under the teaching (magisterio)

of the Church can never have any just cause for changing or doubting that faith (can. vi). Therefore give thanks to God the Father, who has made us worthy to be partakers of the lot of the saints in light;20 let us not neglect so great a salvation, but with our eyes fixed on Jesus, the author and finisher of our faith, let

" I Tim. ii. 4. M Col. i. 12.

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us hold fast the confession of our hope with out wavering.21

CHAPTER IV Of Faith and Reason

The Catholic Church, with one consent, has also ever held, and does hold, that there is a twofold order of knowledge, distinct both in principle and in object: in principle, because our knowledge in the one is by natural reason, and in the other by divine faith; in object, be cause, besides those things to which natural reason can attain, there are proposed to our belief mysteries hidden in God, which, unless divinely revealed, cannot be known (can. i). Wherefore the Apostle, who testifies that God is known by the Gentiles through created things,22 still, when discoursing of the grace and truth which come by Jesus Christ,23 says : "We speak the wisdom of God in a mystery, a wisdom which is hidden, which God ordained before the world unto our glory; which none,

*Heb. xii. 2; x. 23. 22 Rom. i. 20. 23John i. 17.

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of the princes of this world knew; . . . but to us God hath revealed them by His Spirit. For the Spirit searcheth all things, yea, the deep things of God."24 And the Only- begotten Son Himself gives thanks to the Fa ther, because He has hid these things from the wise and prudent, and has revealed them to lit tle ones.25

Reason, indeed, enlightened by faith, when it seeks earnestly, piously and calmly, attains by a gift from God some, and that a very fruit ful, understanding of mysteries; partly from the analogy of those things which it naturally knows, partly from the relations which the mysteries bear to one another and to the last end of man: but reason never becomes capable of apprehending mysteries as it does those truths which constitute its proper object. For the divine mysteries by their own nature so far transcend the created intelligence that, even when delivered by revelation and received by faith, they remain covered with a veil of faith itself, and shrouded in a certain degree of dark ness, so long as we are pilgrims in this mortal

24 1 Cor. ii. 7 ff. * Matt. xi. 25.

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life, not yet with God : for we walk by faith, and not by sight.26

But although faith is above reason, there can never be any real discrepancy between faith and reason; since the same God Who reveals mysteries and infuses faith has bestowed the light of reason on the human mind, and God cannot deny Himself, nor can truth ever con tradict truth. The false appearance of such a contradiction is mainly due, either to the dog mas of faith not having been understood and expounded according to the mind of the Church, or to the inventions of opinion having been taken for the verdicts of reason. We de fine, therefore, that every assertion contrary to a truth of enlightened faith is utterly false.27 Further, the Church, which, together with the apostolic office of teaching, has received a charge to guard the deposit of faith, derives from God the right and the duty of proscribing false science, lest any should be deceived by

20 II Cor. v. 7.

"From the Bull of Pope Leo X, "Apostolic! regiminis," read in Session VIII of the Fifth Lateran Council, A.D. 1513. See Labbe's Councils, vol. xix, p. 842, Venice, 1732.

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philosophy and vain deceit28 (can. ii). There fore all faithful Christians are not only forbid den to defend as legitimate conclusions of sci ence such opinions as are known to be con trary to the doctrines of faith, especially if they have been condemned by the Church, but are altogether bound to account them as er rors which put on the fallacious appearance of truth.

And not only can faith and reason never be opposed to one another, but they are of mutual aid one to the other: for right reason demon strates the foundations of faith, and, enlight ened by its light, cultivates the science of things divine; while faith frees and guards reason from errors, and furnishes it with manifold knowledge. So far, therefore, is the Church from opposing the cultivation of human arts and sciences, that it in many ways helps and promotes it. For the Church neither ignores nor despises the benefits to human life which result from the arts and sciences, but confesses that, as they came from God, the Lord of all science, so, if they be rightly used, they lead

"Col. ii. 8.

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to God by the help of His grace. Nor does the Church forbid that each of these sciences in its sphere should make use of its own prin ciples and its own method; but, while recog nizing this just liberty, it stands watchfully on guard, lest sciences, setting themselves against the divine teaching, or transgressing their own limits, should invade and disturb the domain of faith.

For the doctrine of faith which God has re vealed has not been proposed, like a philo sophical invention, to be perfected by human ingenuity; but has been delivered as a divine deposit to the Spouse of Christ, to be faith fully kept and infallibly declared. Hence, also, that meaning of the sacred dogmas is per petually to be retained which our holy Mother the Church has once

declared; nor is that meaning ever to be departed from, under the pretence or pretext of a deeper comprehension of them (can. iii). Let then the intelligence, science and wisdom of each and all, of indi viduals and of the whole Church, in all ages and all times, increase and flourish in abun dance and vigour ; but simply in its own proper

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kind, that is to say, in one and the same doc trine, one and the same judgment.29

CANONS

OF GOD THE CREATOR OF ALL THINGS

I. If anyone shall deny One true God, Creator and Lord of things visible and invisi ble ; let him be anathema.

II. If anyone shall not be ashamed to af firm that, except matter, nothing exists; let him be anathema.

III. If anyone shall say that the substance and essence of God and of all things is one and the same ; let him be anathema.

IV. If anyone shall say that finite things, both corporeal and spiritual, or at least spir itual, have emanated from the divine sub stance ; or that the divine essence by the mani festation and evolution of itself becomes all things; or, lastly, that God is universal or in definite being, which by determining itself constitutes the universality of things, distinct

29 Vincent of Lerins, Common, n. 28.

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according to genera, species and individuals; let him be anathema.

V. If anyone confess not that the world, and all things which are contained in it, both spiritual and material, have been, in their whole substance, produced by God out of nothing ; or shall say that God created, not by His will, free from all necessity, but by a necessity equal to the necessity whereby He loves Himself; or shall deny that the world was made for the glory of God ; let him be anathema.

OF REVELATION

I. If anyone shall say that the One true God our Creator and Lord, cannot be cer tainly known by the natural light of human reason through created things ; let him be ana thema.

II. If anyone shall say that it is impossi ble or inexpedient that man should be taught by the divine revelation concerning God and the worship to be paid by him ; let him be ana thema.

III. If anyone shall say that man cannot

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be raised by divine power to a higher than nat ural knowledge and perfection, but can and ought, by a continuous progress, to arrive at length of himself to the possession of all that is true and good; let him be anathema.

IV. If anyone shall not receive as sacred and canonical the books of Holy Scripture, en tire with all their parts, as the holy Synod of Trent has enumerated them, or shall deny that they have been divinely inspired; let him be anathema.

OF FAITH

I. If anyone shall say that human reason is so independent that faith cannot be enjoined upon it by God ; let him be anathema.

II. If anyone shall say that divine faith is not distinguished from natural knowledge of God and of moral truths, and therefore that it is not requisite for divine faith that revealed truth be believed because of the authority of God who reveals it ; let him be anathema.

III. If anyone shall say that divine revela tion cannot be made credible by outward signs,

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and therefore that men ought to be moved to faith solely by the internal experience of each, or by private inspiration; let him be anathema.

IV. If anyone shall say that miracles are impossible, and therefore that all the accounts regarding them, even those contained in Holy Scripture, are to be dismissed as fabulous or mythical ; or that miracles can never be known with certainty, and that the divine origin of Christianity is not rightly proved by them ; let him be anathema.

V. If anyone shall say that the assent of Christian faith is not a free act, but necessarily produced by the arguments of human reason; or that the grace of God is necessary for that living faith only which worketh by charity ; let him be anathema.

VI. If anyone shall say that the condition of the faithful and of those who have not yet attained to the only true faith is on a par, so that Catholics may have just cause for doubt ing, with suspended assent, the faith which they have already received under the teaching (ma- gisterio) of the Church, until they shall have obtained a scientific demonstration of the

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credibility and truth of their faith; let him be anathema.

OF FAITH AND REASON

I. If anyone shall say that in divine revela tion there are no mysteries, truly and properly so called, but that all the doctrines of faith can be understood and demonstrated from natural principles by properly cultivated reason; let him be anathema.

II. If anyone shall say that human sciences are to be so freely treated, that their assertions, although opposed to

revealed doctrine, can be held as true, and cannot be condemned by the Church ; let him be anathema.

III. If anyone shall assert it to be possible that sometimes, according to the progress of science, a sense is to be given to doctrines pro pounded by the Church different from that which the Church has understood and under stands ; let him be anathema.

Therefore, fulfilling the duty of Our su preme pastoral office by the mercies of Jesus

Christ, We entreat, and by the authority of the same our God and Saviour We command all the faithful of Christ, and especially those who are set over others or are charged with the office of instruction, that they earnestly and diligently apply themselves to ward off and eliminate these errors from Holy Church, and to spread the light of pure faith.

And since it is not sufficient to shun heretical pravity, unless those errors also be diligently avoided which more or less nearly approach it, We admonish all men of the further duty of observing the constitutions and decrees by which such erroneous opinions as are not here expressly enumerated have been proscribed and condemned by the Holy See.

Given at Rome in public session, solemnly held in the Vatican Basilica in the year of our Lord one thousand eight hundred and seventy, on the twenty-fourth day of April, in the twenty-fourth year of Our Pontificate.

In conformity with the original.

JOSEPH, BISHOP or ST. POLTEN,

Secretary to the Vatican Council.

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